

Episode 2: Once Upon a Time... (1)

January is already half over. During the year-end and New Year holidays, there were various movies I wanted to see, but I only managed to go see "The Inugami Family" (cries). I guess I'll have to work hard with DVD rentals (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Following Episode 1, I thought about "going deeper...", but before that, let me tell you a bit of an old story (?).

It's been over 20 years since I stepped into the animation world. I dropped out of university and got a job (?) at the small finishing production company in Ikebukuro where I'd been working part-time. There I did regular painting work. Since it was over 20 years ago, it was naturally the world of animation cels and paints. To be honest, my hands weren't very fast, but I was still painting about 1000 sheets per month. Since it was a small company, I didn't just do painting - I also operated the trace machine (a machine that transfers in-between animation lines to cels via carbon transfer), delivered cuts to outside staff, managed paint inventory, and did various other things.

That company was very small, but still worked hard with a commitment to quality. I learnt everything - not just technical things about tracing and painting, but the mechanisms of various matters and how to be as a working adult. There were many difficult things, but it was an enjoyable workplace. Most of all, I was happy to feel that I too was making anime.

However, at the end of that year, I had a serious illness and became paralysed on my right side. Later, through rehabilitation, I recovered almost normal function, but inevitably some disability remained in my right hand. So I became left-handed. But with my left hand, I definitely couldn't work like before. So I became centered on management and progress work and cel inspection. And I gradually began to start mimicking colour direction work.

That company mainly did subcontracting for **Toei Doga** (東映動画) (now Toei Animation), taking gross orders for TV series like *Dr. Slump* and *Ai Shite Knight* (愛してナイト) by episode. At that time, Toei Doga's finishing subcontracting production companies included **Suzuki Doga Kikaku** (鈴木動画企画), **Takapro** (タカプロ), **Shin'ei Pro** (新栄プロ), **Kyoei Pro** (協栄プロ), **Studio Crocus** (スタジオクロッカス), **Studio Peacock** (スタジオピーコック), etc., each taking gross orders for 1 or 2 lines of TV series works on rotation.

Now when we talk about colour direction, the mainstream is to do colour direction on key animation checked by animation directors and order **doshi hatchu** (動仕発注) (integrated work from in-between animation through finishing), but back then we received and worked on all cuts that were completed up to in-between animation at finishing. So when we went to Toei Doga to pick up cuts, all 300 cuts for one episode would be completely ready and placed on shelves. Naturally, by the time of editing and dubbing, all cuts were already shot. If you sent out a **dousa** (動撮) (in-between animation photography)! it was a matter for written apologies - that was the era. Amazing, right? (laughs) It was completely different from the current situation where it's mostly layout photography during dubbing.

And basically, the colour direction staff at Toei Doga (they were called **[inspection]** back then) would look through them and add specifications, but scene-specific props would come through as **[leave it to us]** without colour direction. I began my colour direction by doing the colour direction for such items bit by bit.

Also, we couldn't make it on Toei Doga works alone. So we also took on various works from other companies. **Tatsunoko Pro** (タツノコプロ), **Madhouse** (マッドハウス), **Ashi Pro** (葦プロ), **Kaname Pro** (要プロ), **Studio Deen** (スタジオディーン), **Kitty Film** (キティフィルム)... Naturally, we also did Toei Doga theatrical works. Theatrical works were better in terms of pricing, and having the production company's name in the end credits of theatrical works was great publicity within the industry.

We'd take jobs based on our schedule situation, but I was nervous every time. With theatrical works, both the animation and colours were completely different grade from TV. Especially the colour usage in character colour direction, the detailed specifications. The beauty when painted (laughs). Eventually I began to yearn for it: "Colour direction, huh. Ah, this kind of world might be good!"

And well, various things happened (bitter laugh), but in February 1984, I ended up joining Toei Doga. It was early spring when I was 22.

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